

MADHAV MATHUR

sparked immense interest, with the Ayodhya Development Authority expecting a daily influx of up to 5 lakh visitors in the months immediately after the pran prathistha ceremony on January 22.

To accommodate this burgeoning tourism, significant investments are underway. The hospitality sector is booming, with major hotel chains having invested around Rs 350 crore for new hotel constructions, according to industry insiders. Furthermore, the launch of the Maharishi Valmiki International Airport in Ayodhya, capable of handling around 1 million passengers annually, and the introduction of superfast Amrit Bharat and Vande Bharat Express trains are set to enhance connectivity.

But Ayodhya's resurgence is just a part of Uttar Pradesh's broader canvas of spiritual tourism. Cities like Varanasi, Prayagraj, Mathura, Vrindavan, and Naimisharanya are integral components of this vibrant tapestry. Varanasi, for instance, was hosting up to 2 lakh tourists every day during the Sawan month in 2023, highlighting its timeless appeal.

Meanwhile, Mathura and Vrindavan are undergoing extensive infrastructure development with a budget of Rs 25,000-Rs 30,000 crore, according to CM Adityanath, aimed at enhancing their status as major pilgrimage destinations.

The state government's focus on developing religious circuits—the Ramayana, Krishna, and Buddhist circuits—further accentuates the tourism potential. Important Buddhist sites like Sarnath, Kushinagar, Kapilvastu, and Shravasti are being developed, with international airports planned to improve global connectivity. Naimisharanya and Chitrakoot, with their deep mythological significance, are also part of this grand vision.

This comprehensive development plan, under the guidance of Prime Minister Modi and Chief Minister Adityanath, is transforming Uttar Pradesh into a global hub for religious and spiritual tourism.

In summary, the inauguration of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya is more than just a religious event; it's a transformative milestone that is reshaping Uttar Pradesh's identity as a leading destination for spiritual tourism, blending cultural heritage with modern development. ■